Chapter 10 – The Delhi Sultanate

The next period of Indian history centered on the exploits of the Turk, Qutb al-Dīn Aibak. By Aibak's lifetime in the 12th century CE, Islam had become a distinct culture within India through simple migration. Though some land disputes and clashes had taken place on a small scale, it was not until the 11th century CE that members of Islam decided on a political tactic of complete Indian subjugation under the great and powerful Persian Empire.

Born in Turkistan, Aibak was sold into slavery to a Persian who took him away from his homeland as a child. In Persia, he served a succession of important masters that eventually included the Sultan of the Ghorid Empire. Evidently a trustworthy and clever bondsman, Aibak was granted the title of Master of Slave by the sultan himself. Proving himself more than capable of such administration, Aibak was ultimately appointed to the high office of military general for the sultan's army, which had been tasked with the conquest of the Indian city of Delhi. Thus, Qutb al-Dīn Aibak found himself in India around the year 1193.

Delhi did indeed fall to the Ghorid army, after which the sultan returned home and left the administration of the city and other conquered north Indian lands to Aibak. Happy with his charge, Aibak continued to add more regions of India to the Ghorid territories until his master was assassinated in 1206. Seeing his opportunity to become the unquestioned ruler of the lands he had been integral in obtaining, Aibak married the heir of his only political rival in Persia and declared himself the Sultan of Delhi.

Qutb al-Dīn Aibak died only four years after having established his kingdom, but the lands he'd annexed in India and adjacent regions remained united under a succession of sultans. The Delhi Sultanate, as it came to be known, had only penetrated into the utmost northern region of modern India and also contained lands within Bangladesh, Pakistan, Nepal, and Bhutan. The first to rule this kingdom after Aibak—one of his own sons—was quickly murdered by the deceased sultan's son-in-law, Shams ud-Din Iltutmish, who took the leadership role for himself. This was the beginning of the Slave (or Mamluk) Dynasty, the first of five Delhi-based dynasties governed by a series of sultans of Turkic origin.

The entire Delhi Sultanate, as this collection of dynasties is called, spanned more than 300 years between 1206 to 1526. Thus, Turks essentially kept